million across Solapur, Sangli, Kolhapur, Latur and Nanded. Their representative bodies have revived a decade-old demand, asking members to mark their religion as 'Lingayat' or 'Veerashaiva–Lingayat', not 'Hindu'.

"Culturally, we are Hindus, but we belong to the Lingayat religion," says Vijaykumar Hatture of the Jagatik Lingayat Mahasabha. A recent conclave of some 19 community bodies in Nanded passed a resolution insisting on this distinction, says Avinash Bhosikar, national coordinator, Lingayat Samanvaya Samiti, and president, Basava Brigade.

Not everyone is on board: the Jangam priestly subgroup is resisting any move away from the Hindu label. Caste plays out within the fold in other ways too: the splittists are advising their brethren to specifically mention their *jati* along with religion.

It's unambiguous enough. Manohar Dhonde of the Shiva Veerashaiva Yuvak Sanghatana says a June 15 conference of various *math* pontiffs and caste folk at Latur's Ahmedpur will lead to a statewide awareness drive on the separate religion demand.

Religion encounters caste likewise with Dalit Buddhists, erstwhile Mahars who converted with Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar. They are being urged to register both their religion (as 'Buddhist') and their original caste in the census, besides mentioning Pali as a language they know. The backdrop? The state plan to have sub-categorisation within Scheduled Caste reservations—i.e. quotas within quotas for Dalit castes who claim Mahars have hitherto claimed most benefits. This is the Dalit Buddhist counter. Their logic? "Everything depends on the numbers," says Bhimrao Ambedkar, grandson of Dr Ambedkar and Bharatiya Bauddha Mahasabha chief.

'BUDDHIST' AND 'MAHAR'

The census will clarify how many Dalits are Buddhists and how many there are in all. Then they can rationally argue for a larger share of quotas and population-linked welfare funds. The data would justify raising SC-reserved Lok Sabha seats in the state from five to eight and assembly seats from 29 to 49, while pushing the Dalit quota in education and jobs from 13 to 18 per cent, he adds.

In the 2011 census, Buddhist Dalits had marked themselves variously. Not again, says student leader Chandrashekhar Kamble, affiliated to Union minister Ramdas Athawale's Republican Party of India. Clarity will avert any impact on quotas, he says.

Bharat Shelke of the Secular Movement, an internal sceptic, says Ambedkarism should shed caste. But a census may find such views in a minority in a state that lists 59 SC castes—Buddhist Dalits being the largest. ■

Takeaways

- **Census 2027 will start caste count beginning Feb. Social blocs mobilising on key demands**
- **Lingayats ask caste brethren to mark themselves as a separate religion, along with their *jatis***
- **Buddhist Dalit groups too say religion must be tagged, alongside origin caste 'Mahar'**

▶ ANDHRA PRADESH

Social Pot Simmers in Rayalaseema

A series of incidents shows a hitherto peaceful Andhra Pradesh turning newly vulnerable to communalism

By **Prasad Nichenametla**

POST-BIFURCATION IN 2014, WITH THE OLD capital Hyderabad also gone, Andhra Pradesh seemed to have largely left behind its history of Hindu-Muslim conflict at exactly the time it came into renewed focus elsewhere. But this has changed of late as an air more hospitable to the politics of religious polarisation seeps into the residual state. A string of incidents since 2021 had borne witness to that. In May, Kadapa's Almaspet junction—in inland Rayalaseema—exhibited it in all its new colours. All over a name.

The dispute centred around the domed gazebo at the roundabout—as secular a structure as you want. Muslim groups had expressed a wish that the crossroads be named after Tipu Sultan. In February, the municipal corporation passed a resolution supporting this, pending approval, but the official notification didn't materialise. Hindutva groups, strongly opposed to the idea, preferred the name 'Hanuman Circle', in deference to a nearby temple.

A CIRCLE BY ANY NAME

Trouble erupted as both sides gathered in large numbers at the spot on May 9. Both carried banners proclaiming their desired name and flung at each other first slogans—then stones. A lathicharge ensued. On May 12, the Hindu side, under heavy police security, installed a 31-foot Hanuman statue at a temple near the circle. The town stayed tense for days. A fact-finding